

Migration, displacement and education

Powerful, moving stories of migration and displacement occur around the world. These stories of ambition, hope, fear, anticipation, ingenuity, fulfilment, sacrifice, courage, perseverance and distress remind us that ‘migration is an expression of the human aspiration for dignity, safety and a better future. It is part of the social fabric, part of our very make-up as a human family’. Yet migration and displacement are ‘also a source of divisions within and between States and societies ... In recent years, large movements of desperate people, including both migrants and refugees, have cast a shadow over the broader benefits of migration’.

While there is shared responsibility for the common destiny formally endorsed in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, migration and displacement continue to elicit some negative responses in modern societies. These are exploited by opportunists who see benefit in building walls, not bridges. It is here that education’s role to ‘promote understanding, tolerance and friendship among all nations, racial or religious groups’, a key commitment in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, takes centre stage.

This report looks at migration and displacement through the eyes of teachers and education administrators faced with the reality of diverse classrooms, schoolyards, communities, labour markets and societies. Education systems around the world are united in the commitment to ‘ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all’ and to ‘leave no one behind’. For all students to fulfil their promise, systems need to adjust to their needs irrespective of their backgrounds. They also need to respond to societies’ need to be resilient and adapt to migration and displacement – a challenge affecting countries with large and small migrant and refugee populations alike.

All types of population movement are covered. On average, one out of eight people is an internal migrant. This migration can have serious effects on the educational opportunities of those moving and those left behind, particularly in still rapidly urbanizing low and middle income countries. About 1 out of 30 people lives in a country other than the one where they were born. Almost two-thirds of international migrants are destined for high income countries. While most move to work, some also move for education. And international migration also affects the education of their descendants. Some 1 out of 80 people are displaced within or across borders by conflict or natural disasters. Nine out of ten of these live in low and middle income countries. Including them in national education systems is crucial but can be conditioned by the unique contexts of the displacement.

Migration and displacement interact with education through intricate, two-way relationships that affect those who move, those who stay and those who do or may host migrants and refugees (**Table 1**). When in the life cycle people ponder or undertake migration is a key determinant of education investment, interruption,

TABLE 1:
Selected examples of the relationship between education and migration/displacement

		Effects of migration/displacement on education	Effects of education on migration/displacement
Origin	Migrants	• Migration leads to provision challenges in slums. • Education systems need to adjust to the needs of populations moving in seasonal or circular patterns.	• The more educated are more likely to migrate.
	Left behind	• Migration depopulates rural areas and challenges education provision. • Remittances affect education in origin communities. • Parent absence affects children left behind. • Emigration prospects disincentivize investment in education. • New programmes prepare aspiring migrants.	• Emigration of the educated has consequences for development of affected areas, e.g. through brain drain.
Destination	Immigrants and refugees	• Educational attainment and achievement of immigrants and their children usually lag behind natives. • Refugees need to be included in national education systems. • Refugees’ right to education needs to be ensured.	• Migrants tend to be overqualified, their skills not fully recognized or utilized, and their livelihoods altered. • Internationalization of tertiary education prompts student mobility.
	Natives	• Diversity in classrooms requires better prepared teachers, targeted programmes to support new arrivals and prevent segregation, and disaggregated data.	• Formal and non-formal education can build resilient societies and reduce prejudices and discrimination.